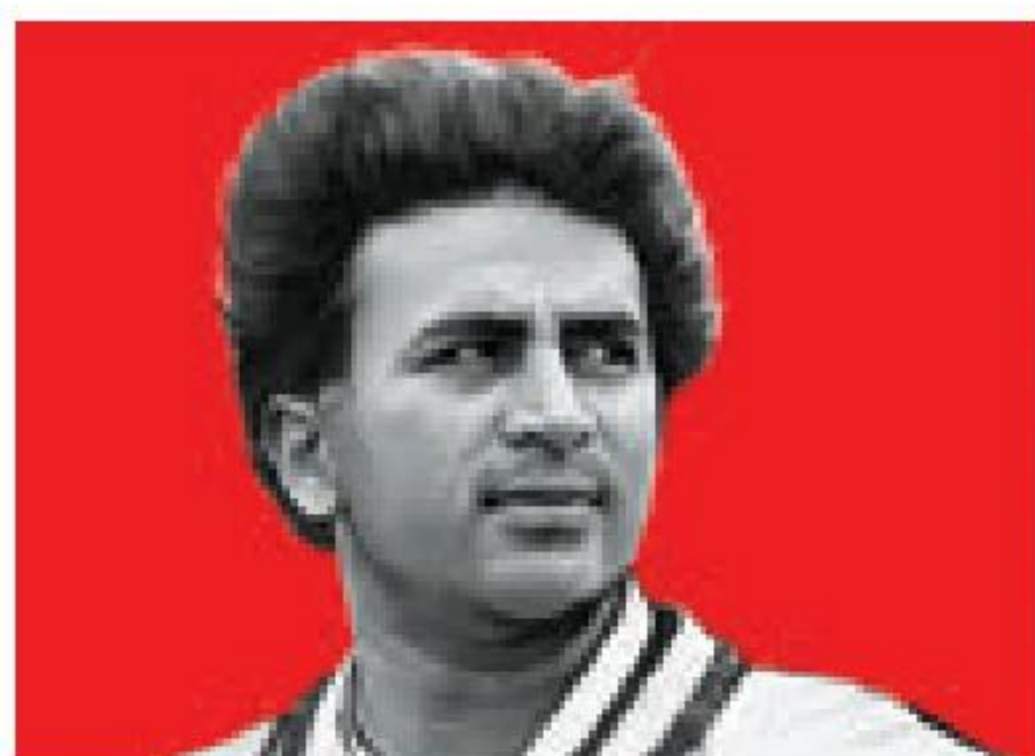




ON THE WRITE LINE

Sunil Gavaskar



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SHUBMAN GILL CAPTAINING NORTH ZONE TEAM IS A MASSIVE SHOT IN THE ARM FOR DULEEP TROPHY

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Now that one of the most exciting Test series has ended, and unbelievably there is no commitment for the men's team till next month's Asia Cup, there will be time for Indian cricket to breathe and take stock of what needs to be done to make this current team even better than what it is today.

For far too long, Indian cricket has tried to live up to its eminent position in the game by ensuring that it sends a team to some of the fellow full member countries so that those countries can benefit from broadcast and gate revenue. While most of the senior and established players take a breather from these tours, those who are trying to concretise their places in the team go through another tour when their minds and bodies could do with a bit of a break.

It was good, therefore, to see that after the tour to Bangladesh was postponed to next year, the BCCI resisted the pressure to send a team for a white-ball series to Sri Lanka this month. By doing that, the BCCI have prioritised domestic cricket, as it means that now most, if not all, of the top players will be available to play in the Duleep Trophy tournament starting shortly. Shubman Gill captaining the North Zone team is

a massive shot in the arm for this tournament. By being available for the tournament, the Indian skipper is sending the right signal to the other members of the team. It would have been understandable if, after a gruelling tour where five Test matches were crammed in a little over six weeks, he had opted to rest. The fast bowlers not playing is good thinking, as it has been an unusually hot summer in England, thanks to global warming, and their energies must have been expended after the untiring spells they bowled throughout the series.

Hopefully, next time around there will be a few more days' gap between Test matches, as suggested by England skipper Ben Stokes. Modern tours are made for senior established players who do not want to spend a day more than is necessary. That leaves the fringe players, as well as those who are out of form, no opportunity to get some form back and make a meaningful contribution to the team. The established players know that come what may, they will not be dropped on form and so want to play the Tests and get back home. This is true for all the teams and is also what home boards seem to like, as it means fewer days looking after the visiting teams.

This was the first-ever series named after